

Paṭiccasamuppāda Leading to Awakening in Ordinary Daily Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 46:10

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

So this book comes from very good work on Dependent Origination by Venerable Prayudh, a senior teacher from Sri Lanka, a well-known scholar. He's written two very good books, very readable, one on *kaṃma* and one on dependent origination. And this is a diagram that comes from his book. He explains it in his own way. So if you get that book, you'll probably get a fuller description than you might get this evening.

The bit at the bottom there is very common. That's the wheel of dependent origination. The word "wheel" comes from the Tibetan tradition, and they, of course, made it into quite a lovely diagram. But in our school, it's just dependent origination in the usual prosaic way.

You'll see that it runs the usual thing: depending on ignorance, here are *sankharas*. You see they've got all sorts of translations for *sankharas* — voluntary impulses, volitional impulses, volitional conditionings, preparations, concoctions — everybody who writes about it finds another word for it. But the thing about *sankharas*, remember, is that they are conditioned and they're also conditioning. So every time a *sankhara* comes up, such as a bit of greed, it's coming up because of past action and it's affecting the future action. So it's condition and conditioning.

Because of that, consciousness comes up. All these things are dependent on each other in a sort of immediacy. Without consciousness, you wouldn't get any *sankhara*. Without *sankhara*, you wouldn't get any consciousness. So it's all a sort of interdependency as well.

And then we got the usual flow from consciousness to body and mind. So in dependent origination, it really is body and mind because it's about this psychophysical organism. But the two words that you'll come across, *nama-rupa*, sometimes refer to materiality and mentality. Name and form, which is really a bit confusing. Anyway, once you've got a body, you've got the six senses. And here again, they refer only to the physical base. It's in the next one, contact, that the mentality comes in. Because at that point, you've got the sense base, you've got the object that it becomes aware of, and you've got consciousness. So at that point, you can say, finally, the body and mind are actually manifesting, moment after moment.

Once we have contact, of course, we have some level of feeling, some sensations. These sensations are physical — the five physical ones, sense of smell, hearing and so on. And on the mind, it's that initial arising of a thought or an image. That's your sense door. That's the mental sense door. And everything from the senses come through the sense door of the mind. So basically what comes in through the physical senses is just original data — very simple data. The ear is just a tapping, just a feeling of the sound waves. And then it's the mind that takes it in and begins to tell you what it is. It's a bell, gives you meaning. It's an alarm bell and tells you what to do. Got to get up. So all that belongs to the mind.

Now, the important thing then, of course, is *vedana*, because at *vedana*, we decide whether what we're experiencing is pleasant or unpleasant. And we went through all that last night. Remember, there's 108 of these pleasant and unpleasant. But I think you can make it very simple that normally we're aware of something that's unpleasant or pleasant and there's that middle bit of neutrality. But if you look closely enough, it shaves into one or the other.

Now, arising with that, of course, is *sanna*, which are your concepts, your perceptions. So *sanna* begins with a sort of photocopy of what's happened. That becomes your memory. And that photocopy grows and grows dependent on how many times you have a similar experience. So every time you eat different biscuits, your idea of a biscuit grows forever until it's as big as a supermarket.

So that's the memory that we have. And it's the memory and the imagination plus these feelings that we work on to develop these dreams and fantasies and realistic things like planning your holiday and what your career is and all that. That's all dependent on those basic components. And those are your *sankharas*.

So not all *sankharas* are bad, remember. And not everything we do begins from a point of ignorance. Sometimes we begin from a point of wisdom. And then you have intentions, proper intentions. And those *sankharas* then are your beneficial habits.

So the Buddha, remember, is liberated in the sense that he no longer identifies with this psychophysical organism. But while he's in it, he's conditioned. So as soon as the organism feels hungry, that's when he gets his bowl and nips out for a bit of food. It's not as though he's not conditioned by the situation he's in, nor does he lose his general personality or his language. Nothing is destroyed apart from this ignorance and what comes out of that wrong understanding — all our acquisition, that sense of always having to acquire something, get something, greed and aversion and fear. Those are your two aversive qualities.

So, dependent on that, of course, we have our reactions and that's *tanha*. And then from that wanting, that original movement towards something that you want, there's then, remember, the identity — I want.

So, remember, that's really important because this is a really crucial discovery by the Buddha because, normally speaking, the I comes first in our experience. The first thing you say is, I want a biscuit. I don't know why I'm on about biscuits all the time. I want a coffee. It always begins with I. I want. And if it's you, I say you want. Or he or she wants, they want. It's always the person comes first.

And what he's saying is, no, that's not true. Psychologically, it comes at the end of the line. Now, if it came at the beginning, you wouldn't find an escape because that identity completely locks you into your desire. As soon as you say, I want ice cream, you're locked into ice cream. You can't escape it if that I is already there.

So it's because of this discovery that the I, the sense of self, the identity comes at the end of the line, that we have the liberation to see the process of desire and find the escape.

And of course, the next one is *bhava*. And from that identity, there comes the empowerment. So *bhava* is the point where the self continues becoming — the sense of becoming. There's the action that it presumes and the force that makes the action, which is your will. So these three things — the will, the action — in fact, the Buddha says will is action. And the sense of self continue on once you've started that wrong identity.

Now, in the Abhidhamma, it does actually point out that if somebody who doesn't have the identity anymore, the wheel still turns. There's still that coming out of wisdom. There's an aspiration or an intention, a wholesome intention, which fires off a certain habit, which then produces an action. The action is known as *kriya*, which is just a way of saying that it's not personal in our way. The way they translate it is "functional." So an action can be wholesome or unwholesome. And for somebody who's completely liberated, it's just functional. It's just like he gets up and he does this and he does that. There's no sense of identity with what they're doing. The identity is, as it were, you might say, fallen back into that sense of mindfulness. Though you have to be careful there because it's not the same as the self that you feel when you're an observer.

So that we've got, and then, of course, you begin the action. And then the action continues and then the action ends. Birth, aging and death.

The classical way from *Visuddhimagga* and Buddhaghosa was to see this in three lives. Your past life was based on ignorance and created certain conditions. And then you were born. Then you have a body and mind and you go through this life. And then when you die, you're born and grow old again and die, dependent on the conditions that you've created through this wheel.

But in the Abhidhamma and even in the scriptures, this is also happening all the time. Every time you fire off something which is dependent on greed, hatred and delusion. So remember, we don't always behave like that. Sometimes we actually do good.

So now here they've got the escape at ignorance. Well, that of course digs deep. And every time in your meditation, you are beginning to see more clearly these three characteristics — the impermanence, the role of desire, and this identity business and the ownership, the possessiveness that we have, sense of control over things. The more we see that and the more we let go of it, the more we perceive its consequences. And of course, we are undermining ignorance as such.

But the real escape from an ordinary daily life experience position would be between the feeling and the *tanha*, the desire, the attachment. It's catching that moment and then just hanging on and just waiting for that unwholesome desire to pass away completely that allows us to rid ourselves of these unwholesome *saṅkharas*. And once we do that, we've found the escape.

And those little arrows that are pointing upwards show us how we can do that. But the important thing is that, first of all, that awareness that we should try to develop all the time of being aware of immediately when some desire arises and to be able to acknowledge whether this is wholesome or not. And if it's unwholesome, to hang on in there, just wait for that power, that energy to die away. And every time you do that, remember, you're deconditioning yourself. So what was perhaps an obsessive action becomes less and less powerful over time. It's not that we're not caught out every so often, but just by that constant effort, we're just rubbing away at the stone until it's completely dissolved.

So dependent origination there just shows us how the first escape comes. Now, you'll see that there are three arrows here: skillful conduct, faith and wise reflection. So these are what we must bring into our daily life. These attitudes in order to really strengthen that path out of suffering.

The one in the middle there, faith — we begin with that. Faith in Buddhism doesn't mean belief like it might do in other religions. It's more to do with confidence, and that confidence comes about through practice. It might have begun for us by just hearing something that made sense to us about Buddhism or meeting a friend who talked about it. And immediately there's enough confidence to go to a meeting. And in the meeting you have enough confidence to have a go at the meditation. And then you have enough confidence to bring it into your daily life. And as you see the benefits of it, your confidence grows.

Now this confidence or faith, *saddha* — the word *saddha* is known as an *indriya*. *Indriya* is translated as a power. It actually comes from the word Indra, who was the main god of the Vedic system. And so it means an empowerment. It means something powerful. A faculty, that's it. They sometimes translate it as a faculty, which doesn't get across the idea that it's actually a power within you — confidence.

If you think of anything in your life which you've gone for, you've had to have that confidence. It's the basis of virtually everything we do. And that confidence, what it does is it makes us commit ourselves. If the confidence isn't there, then we start suffering from doubt. And what doubt does is it undermines our confidence in ourselves. And by doing that, you never commit. So the fact that we are here on this retreat means that we have actually committed. And it's to rejoice in that commitment. It's the basis.

That stupa that we have out in the meadow there — see those first three steps? That's what they symbolise. It symbolises confidence in the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha. And they're polished. They're nicely shaped. Then, of course, the heavy climb comes to get to the top through the rocky ways. I hope you've all read that on the website. Don't know why I bother.

So that confidence is both a practice, but it's also in time to do with the heart, it's to do with some sort of

heart connection. That heart connection is best within a sort of thankfulness, a sort of basic gratitude, both in the teaching and the Buddha. And even through the teachers that we have. And it falls back upon them with that gratitude. It strengthens your commitment because you want to be like the Buddha. You want to follow the path. You want to end up fully liberated like him.

And that's why we have these beacons such as the Mahasi Sayadaw, whom I have on the side there. So having people like that, it gives you that confidence. Well, if they can do it, I can do it. It's like anything, isn't it? Nobody had climbed Everest until Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing got up there. And after that, everybody and his dog gets up there. You get these 90-year-old women getting up there. There was a 70-year-old woman got up there. It's unbelievable. So once the gates open — that's the rejoicing of the Buddha. The Dhamma gates are open. That's how he puts it. The gates of the Dhamma have been opened wide. Once somebody's perceived something, everybody can get through it.

So that sense of confidence, sense of faith is absolutely necessary. And when somebody achieves first path and fruit, it's known as a *bala*, as a power. It becomes unshakable. They might deny it under torture, but in themselves, they know that it's truly correct. But we're weak.

So then there's the one on wise reflection. These are three levels of understanding. The first one is known as *suta-maya panna*. It's the wisdom that comes from reading or listening or receiving some sort of instruction. And that really doesn't become your own until we've thought about it, until it's becoming our own intellectual property, you might say. And then, of course, it's substantiated through our practice, *vipassana*. So there are these three ways that we grow in this wise reflection.

Now, what would be examples of wise reflection? Well, Buddhism talks about the eight worldly conditions. Gain and loss. How much of our daily life is about gaining something? And how much in the past have we suffered from losing something that we gained? Then there's honour and dishonour. How we're viewed by people. Things that have made us feel ashamed or feel guilty. And other things that have made us feel proud, conceited. Then there's happiness and misery. Well, they happen all the time, don't they, happiness and misery? We go through loads of those every day. But these are known as the worldly conditions. And then finally, praise and blame, which is close, I think, to honour and dishonour. So it's again, just looking at the way we behave, the way we pass through a day.

And that *yoniso manasikara*, that wise reflection — it's good in the evening, just to sit quietly and just go through the day. Reflect upon things that we've done, which we're proud about, which we should be proud of. And things that we shouldn't be proud of. It's a case of just going through the day and reflecting on that. And then from the reflection to make some sort of commitment, some sort of decision.

So in the morning there, after chanting, I suggest that you make certain commitments in the morning. Something you want to do, something you don't want to do. So we all know our habits. We all know what we're good at and what we're not so good at. And it's just this daily commitment. Slowly, it does penetrate. It does get through.

I think from a more modern point of view, or should we say from a point of view that we would understand, you might call them the four worldly pursuits, which is sensual pleasure, fame, riches and power. So I think we connect with that much more easily.

So how much of our time is spent on trying to escape suffering by getting into some sort of sensual pleasure? You know, films, calling people up and telling them how miserable you are, things like that. And then you've got things like doing something for fame, which would come under praise. The riches, everyone wants to be rich, for heaven's sake. And power, being able to make other people do what you want them to do. So those are reflections throughout the day, you see. So you might look back and you might think, oh yeah, that was me taking control of the situation and not taking into regard what other people wanted.

There's a lovely little bit in the scriptures where three Arahats are living together and the Buddha asked them, how do they live so well together? And the chief says, the chief monk says, when I get up in the morning, I ask myself, "What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?" And presumably they all say that. I mean, that's the problem with that approach. Everybody has to agree to that idea, yeah? And then you have a fisticuff. So we've got the three characters, yes.

And of course, reflecting always on the three characteristics. Impermanence. You know, but at the end of the day, another day, another day gone. One day closer to the end after a meal. That's it. That's one less lunch in this lifetime. It's like, you know, you just keep doing it with a sense of humour. You don't get yourself miserable. You just note that, in fact, this is one less. Every time, this is one less talk I'm going to give. Right? And it's just pinpointing little pin pricks on the way and slowly you let go.

The whole point of seeing *anicca* is to let go, is to see what's the point of holding on to something. It's gone. And so it brings you much more obviously into the present moment. So this is lunch, that's it, it's gone, fine. It's being able to let go that *anicca* teaches us.

And when it comes to *dukkha*, of course, that's also letting go, seeing these desires. And remember that when we have a desire, if we can stay, this is a wrong desire, if we can stay to the very end of that feeling and just feel that sense of release, it's like you've taken a chain off, you've taken a big weight off your back or something. There's a sense of relief. And then you get this happiness arise of a release, a relief. And then you get that, got out of that one. Didn't get caught up there.

And in a sense, you've got to see that or else you don't see the benefit of renunciation. If it's only misery every time you renounce, you know, like you never get to the end point of a desire, it just feels like a struggle all the time. But if you just hang on in there, if it's a drop, then you get that. Now that's a little touch of *nibbāna* because that's what the Buddha says. The taste of *nibbāna* is freedom. Freedom. Freedom from. It's not freedom to do what you feel like. If only.

And of course, this *anattā*, which again, is about identity. It's about possessiveness. It's about a

relationship which causes a lot of problems, a lot of suffering. And just letting go of that. You know when the self's coming in. You know when you're getting angry with somebody. You get fed up with somebody. You want them to do something and they're not doing it. And you get bored with something. Anytime you feel negative about somebody or something or your job or your work, you know that the self is seeking something else. You know, it's just not happy with the situation. It wants something. It wants excitement. It wants something else.

So as soon as that comes up, it's a case of recognising it. That's the effect of identity possession. And as soon as you drop that, some little connection has gone. See? So we're leading ourselves towards a life of ease, a sense of ease about life. You know, we're not struggling anymore. We're not in conflict with the way things are. It's like, this is the way it is. And that's it. And you work with it. Sometimes, I mean, a lot of times it's not that pleasant, but you work with it.

And a similar reflection which helps us there are the ones that we do in the evening on sickness, ageing and death. And remember, when you contemplate that, very personally, like this body may fall ill. I am ageing. And I will die. And it's gently, gently saying that into our hearts. It's not going to leave it up in the head. I mean, anybody can do that. It's actually speaking so that you're actually touching the heart, touching your emotional centre, your feeling centre. And then you get that response. So there may be a sense of relief that you're accepting it, but there may just be a bit of fear. So you've got to keep at it, you see. And whenever you do that sort of exercise, remember, always remind yourself of the liberation. We're not ending up, the Buddha didn't teach annihilation. There is a good prognosis at the end. It's worth fighting for.

So those sorts of things are the wise reflection that you might do.

And then the third one is the skilful conduct. So this really breaks into things that we shouldn't do, try not to do. So those are your *sīla*, your five training rules, right? That's *sikhāpada*. *Pada* means footsteps. *Sikhā* means trainings, trainings of footsteps, footsteps of training, you know. So I think most of us are pretty clear about that.

But the other one is, of course, to do with the more virtuous side of our nature. And in the evening, we chant this *Mahā Maṅgala Sutta*, the highest blessings. *Mahā* means great, *maṅgala* means blessing. And you'll note that this always leads to happiness. So virtue equals happiness in the Buddha's mind. It's a true happiness. The more virtuous we are, the more happy we will feel.

When we say happy, remember that there are various levels. You might not be happy on a surface level. Might not be happy with this, happy with that, happy with the politics, happy with this, happy with that. It's more to do with this deeper level of happiness, deeper level of contentment, a feeling that your life is worthwhile. That's what gives you that deep happiness.

And this comes out with people who are involved in politics, end up in prison, end up tortured, things like

that. You wonder, you wouldn't really do it, but you wonder, how can they do that? You see, because on the surface of things, absolutely miserable. It's a really terrible experience to have to go through. And some of them die, of course. But it's when you realise that the deep purpose of their lives, some form of political or social liberation, is where their happiness lies. And the giving of their life to that is their deepest happiness. Yeah. So, you know, no greater gift has man than to give his life for another. So we don't understand that unless we redefine what happiness is. So it's like a deep sense of commitment to something virtuous. And if you let go of that, you betray yourself. That's very difficult to forgive when you've betrayed yourself. Yeah.

So you can see he has a whole list of stuff here. And he does start off with something very straightforward, you know, to reside in a beautiful place. Well, a suitable place, excuse me. And to have done meritorious deeds. And then to have a skill, to have something that you can work with, a master of discipline. And then you've got your social responsibilities, looking after your mother, father, your children and all that. And then there's just the basic thing to not to do any harm. And then there's a list of these virtues: reverence, humility, contentment, gratitude. Then patience, gentleness. See, that's all there, isn't it?

I mean, this obviously is not an exhaustive list. It just gives us some idea as to what we should be developing. And then finally, the spiritual things, you know, to listen to Dhamma and to become fully liberated. And these are the highest blessings. So it's reflecting on those sorts of things and then just seeing how we can bring them into our lives. I mean, every day we have opportunities. Every day.

So that brings us to livelihood. And our livelihoods are about service. So a lot of people who end up in work that they were enthusiastic about, and then it gets boring, boring, boring, and all that. It's terrible. The way to break through that is to stop asking for what can the job give me? See, if it's always at that level, you know, how much am I earning? What interest is it giving me? If it's always at that level, then it's very easy to become bored with it. It takes on more meaning when you actually do it for the benefit of others. The benefit for the firm you're working for. And then it gives it a different layer of commitment. And that's what brings your happiness, no matter what you're doing.

And that leads us to lifestyle, you know, to check out our lifestyle. How we're spending our money. How do we spend our time? Who do we spend our time with? All these things have an effect on us. One thing that many of you, I think, will have experienced, I definitely did, is that once you move towards the Dhamma, old friends seem to disappear, new ones seem to come, but somehow you sort of move away from what they were offering through those friendships, which worked at one time, but now they don't have the same meaning. So lifestyle, what you eat, there's a whole load of stuff that we can reflect upon there.

Then there's this virtuous circle. It's in the commentaries. I don't think it's made so explicit in the discourses, but this whole thing about gratitude, renunciation and generosity. So when you think about all the things that we've been given, which we couldn't possibly repay, you know, you can't repay your parents for your birth. You can't repay them for all the terrible times they had to have with you as a kid.

You can't, you know, the society, what society has given us, its education, its health.

None of this would be affordable at an individual level. You have to earn masses of money to get yourself educated and to get yourself healed. It's because of a communal effort that we're able to have these benefits. And so if you actually go through all the things you've received for which you can't, for which were gratis, there's no. And nobody's asking you, you know, to give back to pay for the education you've had. I mean, now I know they do for university, but I was one of the lucky ones. But at least until 18, when you've reached legal manhood, everything's given freely and the national health system. All the social support systems that we have, you know. The police.

See, where would it be about the police? Ah, see. It's funny. There's always a certain negativity about the police because of their authority. And you're like, you know, the cops are coming. But in fact, we need them. And, you know, I know a meditator, he's a policeman, and he says, you know, he's out on the line every night, sometimes in very dangerous circumstances, laying his life on the line, you know, so it's no easy job for them sometimes.

So when you actually recall that as a gift, then, of course, there's a natural desire to repay. And that's where the generosity comes from. Now, every time you give something, whether it's of your time or of your wealth, you're renouncing something that you could have spent on yourself. You could have been watching a film or something, or you could have been spending your money on some other rubbish. But now you're actually giving it for the benefit of somebody else. And that means letting go of something that you would have done for yourself. So there's a little bit of, shall we say, discomfort there.

And any offering you make of your time or wealth, which doesn't have that little bit of discomfort, means it's comfortable. It means you're not really renouncing. There's got to be an edge to giving if you want to actually grow in generosity. Yeah. I mean, if a person wants to keep at the same level of generosity, that's fine. You know what I mean? It's just the more you give, the more you renounce, the more you are letting go. So remember, the whole of the spiritual life really is in that word renunciation. And let's not confuse that with self-mortification, which is a completely different philosophy. It's about blaming the body for things and stuff like that. But it's renouncing something, restraint, you know, these words are very big in the Buddha's vocabulary: restrained, restraining, renouncing.

So that's those, you know very quickly, those cover those first three basic attitudes or modes, you see. And the consequence of that, the first consequence is gladness. So gladness is really referring to a feeling of being free from guilt and shame. You know, not having those feelings within us and a growth in self-esteem and self-confidence. That's what comes with virtue. You feel good about yourself.

And because of that, the concentration is easier. And because the concentration is easier, then the rapture comes. The rapture here is a big word, actually, but it just means feeling really good. I mean, we're talking about everyday life. We're not talking about deep, heavy, profound meditational states. Just feeling, you know, feeling really good about ourselves, good about the world, even though we see it's not all brilliant.

And with that sense of happiness, there comes just a natural calmness about things. And then with that calmness, that happiness, the calmness and then the happiness is just that combination of those things. Combination of feeling at ease, feeling good about yourself, feeling good about other people, feeling good about your situation. Yeah. Feeling okay about your situation, you might not be brilliant, you know. And that brings you to a level of what you might call happiness, just a way of being in the world.

And then with that, of course, the concentration comes. And with concentration, the commitment to moment-to-moment mindfulness in daily life, yeah, insights arise quite naturally. I mean, in the Mahāsi tradition, it's well known, really, that people have insights more off the cushion than on it. Because just for that moment, they've given up trying. But they've come off the cushion with a sense of concentration, calmness, peace. And then, as it were, it liberates the awareness, the intuitive awareness to see things. So that's your knowledge and insight.

And this leads to disenchantment. Disenchantment with what? With the world as a place to seek permanent happiness. That's the disenchantment. It's not as though you can't be happy in the world, but you're not seeking perfect happiness anymore. You're not trying to manipulate the world always to make yourself happy.

And this leads again, these are very close to each other, dispassion, which is similar. I mean, it's just not getting het up about things, not being more accepting about things, dispassion. And then finally, of course, the liberation, the freedom from suffering.

And the *āsava*, the outflows, it's funny, they're translated as outflows, influx, inflow, canker, floods, effluence. I mean, you know, anybody who wants to translate this word. But basically, it's the four, well, three actually, one was added later. The three platforms upon which everything arises. So they won't come to you as a great surprise. It's desire. Desire is something that floods us. It's coming out of this ignorance and it just floods our whole life. Think of it as a flooding of everything that we do. It's there, you know, or a poisoning, a subtle poisoning. I think it's been translated as that.

And then there's the desire to become, to constantly recreate ourselves. So that's the self. So there's the desire, there's the self. And of course that fundamental ignorance that's under there. So it's like you don't know and therefore you keep making the same mistake. When we don't know something, we presume we know.

And then that leads us constantly into making the same mistake. So this perhaps is more obvious in relationships, where somebody might find themselves constantly falling in love. And then, "I don't know what I saw in that person." And that keeps going for a few times. And then they realize it's not the other person's fault, it's them. Those sorts of insights come just by way of this constant reflection.

This leads us really back to the beginning of this *saddha*, this commitment, and seeing that commitment as a necessary starting point. That's the purpose of taking refuges and precepts. Everyone takes them at their

own level of understanding, but it's a point where you commit yourself. This is it, right? That commitment, remember, is a moment-to-moment commitment. It doesn't mean to say that you can't become a Muslim. Why not? It just means that so long as this path is making sense to you, you'll keep at it. You'll keep going with it. And it's based upon that confidence which has arisen out of your personal practice, your personal experience.

I remember in my own case, when I started practising Zen and I used to go up to Throstle Hole, I think it was about one and a half years. It must have been about one and a half years that this feeling of really committing myself, of saying, "Right, well, I'm not going to look around anymore. This makes total sense to me." And went through their ceremony of Jukai, which takes about five days actually. By the end of it, you really feel you've committed yourself.

So taking refuges and precepts, even if you don't want to do it on a social level as an actual ceremony—every morning to have some point where you actually repeat to yourself: "Today, I'm putting confidence in the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha. And today, just for today, I'm not going to behave in an immoral way." That sort of continuous commitment every day has its effect.

So there was quite a bit in this little diagram. I'm glad I have come across it in the past, but I didn't see the potential. I think it can be taken as a meditational thing, but it's because of this right skilful conduct that turns it into a daily life process. That's what I found really interesting.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion and hopelessness, and that by your commitment to the path you will be liberated sooner rather than later.

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